

ALONE and UNSAFE

It's a stretch of road that connects two of emerging Delhi's most modern landmarks, a thriving movie theatre and a luxury mall. There are two police stations, a little over a kilometre apart that straddle the road, nestled amid apartment blocks that house families of mostly middle-class professionals. It's an urban cocoon that should have proved familiar for Headlines Today producer Soumya Viswanathan who had been living here for over a decade. But it was not. At 3.30 a.m. on September 30, she was found dead in her car, a Zen, its left window smashed and its wheels jammed into the divider. Even over a week after what was initially thought to be a road accident, the police have no clue about who could have shot the 25-year-old. All that the working women of the city, and their worried families, have got so far is a comment from Chief Minister Sheila Dikshit that women should not be too adventurous. But for those who have to work, often late into the night, commuting to office is not a luxury, a testing of freedom's limits. It is a necessity. As it was for TV executive Nikita Bajaj whose wrist was slashed when travelling in an auto in Mumbai or Sunitha Narahari, partner in a Delhi law firm, who felt someone breathing down her neck as she opened the door to her apartment one night. These are stories of five women and their nightmares, repeated across urban India, every day, every night. Women for whom the anonymity of the city is the enemy within.



15%

rise in crimes against women has been recorded in India since 2002. Delhi tops the list among urban offenders.

58%

of rape victims in India are women aged between 18-30, while 15.5 per cent between 30 and 50 years.